
The Playbook

Every move that raises your band.
Nothing else.

Read this one. The 226-page War Book is the reference — open it only when you want the evidence behind a move. This is what you actually do.

THE PLAYBOOK

Everything you actually do. Nothing you don't.

First: you need less than you think

Your overall band is the average of four papers, rounded to the nearest half. **An average of 6.75 is reported as 7.0.**

L	R	W	S	You get
7.0	7.0	6.5	6.5	7.0 ✓
7.5	7.5	6.0	6.5	7.0 ✓
6.5	6.5	6.5	6.5	6.5 ✗

From 6.5 in everything, you need **two more half-bands. Not four sevens.**

Where they are cheapest:

Paper	You have	You need	Gap
Listening	26–29 = 6.5	30 = 7	1 mark from the top of 6.5
Reading	27–29 = 6.5	30 = 7	1 mark from the top of 6.5

Listening and Reading are boxes that are right or wrong. No opinion, no examiner. **That is where you buy your band.**

If you do only five things

1 Fix your articles.

the society → society. But *the government* keeps its *the*.

→ The single biggest difference between band 6 and band 7 writers with your first languages.

2 Answer every part of the Task 2 question.

Two views asked for? Give both, plus your opinion, with equal weight.

→ Miss one part and you are capped at band 5 on Task Response.

3 Develop every idea: claim → because → so what → example.

Never state a point and move on.

→ This is what separates band 6 from band 7 more than anything else.

4 On computer Reading, copy-paste the answer from the passage.

Never type it. Ctrl+C, Ctrl+V.

→ Makes spelling errors impossible on completion questions.

5 Slow down when you speak.

Speaking fast to sound fluent is a band-6 marker.

→ Fluency means not stopping, not speed.

The 60-second proofread — run this on every piece of writing

Last three minutes. In this order. Most expensive first.

1. **Articles** — every abstract noun. *the society* ✗ · *the government* ✓
2. **Words ending in -s** — is it uncountable? *informations* ✗ *researches* ✗
3. **Third-person -s** — he *work* ✗ → he *works* ✓
4. **Long sentences** — over 25 words? Find where it should have ended.
5. **Word count** — on screen, bottom left. Subtract anything you copied.

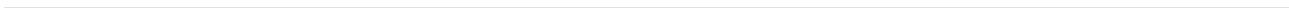
Delete and repair. Never add. New sentences written in a panic carry new errors.

Five things to phone your test centre about

Nobody publishes these. One call answers all five.

- Are the keyboards **AZERTY or QWERTY**? *You type your Writing paper on them.*
- Is **One Skill Retake** available there?
- Is Speaking the **same day**?
- **Pen or pencil** — do you bring one or do they provide it?
- Confirm you are booked for **computer-delivered IELTS**, not IELTS Online.

⚠ **IELTS Online is a different product and is not accepted for immigration.** You need a student visa. Do not book it.



LISTENING — the moves

The arithmetic: Band 6 = 23/40 · band 6.5 = 26–29 · **band 7 = 30**. From 29 the gap is one mark; from 23 it is seven. All of them are boxes holding the wrong string.

1 Never write two answers in one box.

Pick one. Hedging with both scores zero even when one is right.

→ Turns a 50% chance into a certain zero.

2 Fill all forty boxes. Never leave one empty.

No negative marking. Guess one answer of the right type and move on.

→ Every blank is a zero you chose.

3 Miss a gap? Move on inside two seconds.

Answers come in order for every type, matching and maps included. Type a guess, jump forward.

→ Hunting backwards turns one lost mark into three.

4 Read the word limit above every single task.

Limits change inside one paper. Under TWO WORDS, stop at two even if the third is true.

→ One word over = zero on a correct answer.

5 Label every gap in the reading window.

Write the category and word class: surname, price, number+unit, noun, verb.

→ Converts listening into slot-matching. Worth 2–3 marks.

6 Learn the correction trap in both directions.

Sorry, I mean = answer comes after. *Just six euros, usually nine fifty* = answer comes first.

→ 1–2 marks. Most candidates only know the first one.

7 Read all ten Part 4 questions in the opening window.

There is no second window. The mid-part pause is unannounced and is not reading time.

→ Protects up to 10 marks in one part.

8 Write the words you hear. Never paraphrase.

There is no vocabulary credit in Listening. Your better synonym is a wrong answer.

→ Every rephrase is a whole mark gone.

9 Type answers as you listen. Never take notes.

The audio does not wait. Prose in the margin is a mark you did not type.

→ Note-taking costs answers in Parts 3 and 4.

10 Never type an article you were not forced to type.

the, a, in, on all count toward the word limit.

→ Can cost a mark; can never gain one.

11 Target 10/10 on Part 1.

Names, numbers, prices, spelled-out words. Slow, clear, twice-stated.

→ Cheapest ten marks in the test. Never concede them.

12 Never add -s to English uncountables.

informations, researches, advices, equipments, feedbacks, softwares — each is a straight zero.

→ Your highest-frequency Listening spelling loss.

13 On maps, put your cursor on the entrance.

Track the speaker's body, not the page. When you hear "turn", rotate.

→ Fixing left/right to the page inverts half the plan.

14 Drill the spatial prepositions as a closed list.

opposite · next to · adjacent to · beyond · past · behind · in front of · at the far end.

→ In a map task the preposition is the answer.

15 Circle TWO or THREE before you read the options.

A "choose TWO" item occupies two question numbers. Two numbers, two letters.

→ Answering one letter throws away a mark.

16 Flag four questions maximum, never ten.

On computer there is no transfer time — two minutes to check, three seconds per answer.

→ Flag everything and you have flagged nothing.

17 Type normally. No ALL CAPS, no spelling anxiety.

Capitalisation is ignored and American spellings are accepted — *meter, center, program, labor*.

→ Saves keystrokes, kills typos, frees weeks of study time.

18 Train five accents, not two.

UK, US, Australia, New Zealand, Canada. Sixty seconds of audio, write only numbers and names.

→ Parts 2 and 4 are one voice each — ten marks apiece.

The 3 traps, in one line each

- **The loudest option is the rejection.** The name you hear clearest is usually the one being turned down — listen for the comparative (*the top one, the cheaper one*), not the names.
- **The late reversal.** Two sentences of enthusiasm, then four words that cancel it (*Forget that one, then*) — never commit before the final clause of an item.
- **Status words.** *Proposed* is not *actual* and *modern* is not *recently opened* — read what tense and status each gap demands before the audio starts.

READING — the moves

The arithmetic: Band 6 = 23–26/40 · band 6.5 = 27–29 · **band 7 = 30**. From 27 the gap is three marks: one added article, one added plural, one answer over the limit.

1 Copy-paste every completion answer.

Select the word in the passage, copy, paste, then count words against the rubric.

→ Makes spelling errors structurally impossible. Your biggest single block.

2 Never leave a blank. Reserve the last three minutes.

Sweep every unanswered box and put something in it.

→ Three marks if you currently time out on Passage 3.

3 Stop at twenty minutes per passage. Hard stop.

Nineteen, nineteen, nineteen, plus a three-minute sweep. Ceiling of 90 seconds per question.

→ Prevents the Passage 3 collapse that costs 5+ marks.

4 FALSE needs a sentence you can point at.

No contradicting sentence, no FALSE. If you are building an argument, it is NOT GIVEN.

→ The single biggest avoidable loss on the paper.

5 Write the word limit at the top of every set.

It changes between sets in the same paper. Over the limit is marked wrong.

→ Mechanical marks recovered with zero reading improvement.

6 Never read the passage through first.

Survey the layout 20 seconds, skim first and last sentences, then scan only where the question sends you.

→ Reading 2,500 words at comprehension speed eats your hour.

7 Vague in the text, precise in the statement: NOT GIVEN.

Text says *numerous*, statement says *most* — no basis to confirm or deny.

→ The item candidates fail most often.

8 Narrow in the passage, wide in the statement: NOT GIVEN.

Unless the text says something about the extra part that rules the statement out – then FALSE.

→ Costs several marks at once, because these cluster.

9 Learn which types run in passage order.

Ordered: multiple choice, T/F/NG, Y/N/NG, sentence endings, sentence completion, short answer. Resume from the last answer.

→ One scan instead of six.

10 Do matching information last, paragraph by paragraph.

Read paragraph A, then look through all the points. Never question-by-question.

→ Eight reads instead of forty-eight scans.

11 Matching headings: work the paragraphs top to bottom.

The questions run in paragraph order; the Roman numerals are scrambled.

→ Never expect heading (i) to belong to paragraph A.

12 Answer from the text before you uncover the options.

Cover A–D, locate the region, say the answer in your own words, then match.

→ Reading options first guarantees you find the distractor.

13 Never write one letter on a "Choose TWO" item.

It is worth two marks and either order is accepted. Write your certain letter plus your best guess.

→ A free mark thrown away every time.

14 Never write two answers in one gap.

One correct answer inside the pair still scores zero.

→ Zero on a question you had right.

15 Add no article, plural or preposition the gap did not ask for.

The passage says *agate* – write *agate*, not *the agate*, not *polished agate*.

→ Your two commonest Writing errors become whole marks here.

16 On word-bank summaries, stop searching the passage.

The bank words are paraphrases and often appear nowhere in the text. Decide by meaning.

→ Every option fits grammatically, so grammar decides nothing.

17 Read the subordinator before the clause.

Although the yield rose and *Because the yield rose* give opposite T/F/NG answers.

→ One word flips the answer on factual items.

18 Learn phrasal verbs before any subject glossary.

rule out · account for · bear out · bring about · carry out · put down to.

→ Exactly what question stems paraphrase with. Your best vocabulary hour.

The 3 traps, in one line each

- **Same words, wrong paragraph.** Distractors are built from the passage's own vocabulary — look for the information, not the words.
- **The absolute that is not FALSE.** *All / never / only* in a statement is not automatic FALSE; check whether a sentence actually excludes the case, otherwise it is NOT GIVEN.
- **French false friends flipping the answer.** *actually* = in fact · *eventually* = in the end · *sensible* = level-headed · *assist* = help · *support* = back · *formation* = shape.

WRITING TASK 1 — the moves

The clock: 0–5 plan · 5–17 write · stop at 17 · check to 20. **The shape:** intro (1 sentence) → overview (2) → body 1 → body 2. No conclusion.

1 Write the overview before you write any detail.

Two sentences, no figures, naming the biggest pattern. Start it "Overall,".

→ Without it, Task Achievement is capped. Cheapest mark in Task 1.

2 Group the data. Never list it.

Decide two groups before typing: what rose / what fell, or top / middle / negligible.

→ Grouping is the 6-to-7 gate. A perfect list is a 6.

3 Ask first: is there a time axis?

No time axis means no *rose, fell, increased* — comparison language only.

→ A trend verb on a static chart is a factual error.

4 Decide the tense in five seconds.

Dated past → past simple. "Today" → present perfect. Undated → present simple. Man-made process → present passive.

→ Stops one wrong decision repeating across 180 words.

5 Never copy the prompt or the chart title.

Rewrite it in one sentence: change the nouns and the verb, keep the meaning.

→ Copied words are subtracted before counting, and prove you cannot paraphrase.

6 Strip "the" off bare general nouns.

car use, tourism, cycling, electricity consumption. Keep it in *the number/proportion/majority of*.

→ Your highest-frequency error, and it is marked as grammar.

7 Drill the figure prepositions.

rose **from** 4 **to** 11 · rose **by** 7 · peaked **at** 11 · a peak **of** 11 · stable **at** 5.

→ "Rose to" and "rose by" are different facts. French leaks here.

8 Match the word to the size of the change.

Plummeted for a 3% fall is wrong. Rotate *sharply* · *steadily* · *gradually* · *marginally*.

→ Wrong intensity costs twice — accuracy and vocabulary.

9 Report only what you can see.

No causes, no opinions, no predictions, no conclusion paragraph.

→ Every line of commentary is irrelevant content and spent words.

10 Replace repeated nouns with reference words.

this shift · *the former* · *the latter* · *both* · *doing so* · *the remaining two categories*.

→ Fastest cohesion upgrade available. Almost nobody drills it.

11 Split any sentence with two figure-pairs and two "and"s.

Full stop, or subordinate it with *while*, *whereas*, *although*.

→ One 60-word run-on wipes out four clean sentences.

12 Say what did not change.

Name the flat line, the stable share, the untouched building.

→ A constant is a main feature. Most candidates skip it.

13 Approximate when the axis is unlabelled.

just over 40,000 · *in the region of 200* · *some 15 per cent* · *upwards of half*.

→ "Nearly" means below, "well over" means above. Wrong side = error.

14 Write 170–190 words and stop at seventeen minutes.

Check the counter when the overview ends: you should be at 55–70.

→ Overrunning here costs a full band on the task worth double.

Sentence starters that always work

Intro (any visual)

The chart shows how [X] changed in [three countries] between [1990] and [2010].

Overview — trend

Overall, [group A] rose steadily across the period, whereas [group B] moved in the opposite direction.

Overview – comparison, no time axis

Overall, the figures fall into two clear groups: [A] and [B] are far higher than the remaining three.

Overview – process

Overall, the process falls into three broad phases: [collection], [conversion] and finally [packing].

Overview – map

Overall, [Ashcombe] has been transformed from a [farming] settlement into a [residential] one, and only [the church] remains unchanged.

Detail – trend, shape 1

[Car use] rose steadily from [4 million] in [1990] to [11 million] in [2010], peaking at [11.4 million] before levelling off.

Detail – trend, shape 2 (alternate with shape 1)

There was a sharp rise in [car use] over the same period.

Comparison

[Country A] used more than twice as much water per head as [Country C], while [Country E] lagged well behind both.

Proportion

[Packaging] accounted for [34] per cent of the total, making it the largest single category.

Process step

Once the [glass] has been [sorted], it is [washed] before being [crushed into cullet].

WRITING TASK 2 — the moves

The clock: 0–5 plan · 5–37 write · stop at 37 · check to 40. **The shape:** intro (position stated) → body 1 → body 2 → conclusion.

1 Count the demands in the last line. Answer every one.

Discuss both views and give your own opinion = three demands = three things visibly on the page.

→ Answering one part of a two-part prompt limits you to band 5.

2 Build every body paragraph: claim → because → so what → example.

Four moves, roughly 100 words. Never leave a claim standing alone.

→ This is the whole 6-to-7 difference. Nothing else buys more.

3 State your position in the last sentence of the introduction.

One unambiguous sentence. Not "there are arguments on both sides".

→ A position stated late reads as a position tacked on.

4 Two developed ideas, not four asserted ones.

At 280 words, four ideas get 70 each — that is assertion length.

→ Underdeveloped main ideas are the named band-6 fault.

5 Write four or five paragraphs with a blank line between each.

Decide the paragraph count before you type the first word.

→ Weak paragraphing drags you to band 5 on its own.

6 Paraphrase the prompt. Never lift a clause.

Change the nouns and the verb; keep the proposition exactly.

→ Copied words earn nothing, are not counted, and expose weak vocabulary.

7 Put your stance in every topic sentence.

"The stronger reason for rejecting this is..." — not *"Another factor is..."*.

→ Neutral bodies with an opinion at each end is the classic 6.

8 Cap discourse markers at two per paragraph. Never zero.

Delete *Firstly* · *Moreover* · *Furthermore* · *In addition* stacked at sentence heads.

→ Linker overuse actively lowers your cohesion band.

9 Use reference and substitution instead of connectors.

that mismatch · *these pressures* · *this shift* · *the former* · *one* · *so*.

→ Highest-value cohesion move available to a band-6 writer.

10 Hedge every generalisation.

tends to · *appears to* · *is likely to* · *in most cases* · *broadly* · *often*.

→ Raises vocabulary and kills the band-7 over-generalising weakness at once.

11 Concede once, then counter.

"While *X* is undeniably true, it is an argument about timing, not about cars."

→ Proves a developed position and hands you a free complex structure.

12 Name the actor, the instrument and the mechanism.

Not "*governments should raise awareness*" — say who does what, and why it works.

→ Vague remedies lose on relevance and on word choice together.

13 Make the conclusion give a reason, not a summary.

Name the criterion the verdict rests on: permanent vs temporary, shared vs narrow.

→ A restated introduction is repetition, which is a named band-6 fault.

14 Write 270–290 words. Floor 260, no ceiling that matters.

Do not cut a well-developed 320 to hit a number. Do not pad.

→ Two properly developed ideas will not fit inside 250.

15 Never open with a memorised line.

Kill "*In this contemporary era of rapid globalisation...*" and every relative.

→ Formulaic openers are listed as evidence of a low band.

16 Learn ten topic nouns, not twenty synonyms.

curriculum · *attainment gap* · *drop-out rate* · *vocational training* · *contact hours*.

→ Reaching for rare words without collocation control is band-6 behaviour.

17 Spend the last three minutes on four separate sweeps.

Articles → plural uncountables → comma splices → third-person -s. One pass each.

→ These four are systematic errors, and systematic is what caps you.

18 In those three minutes, delete and repair. Never add.

A sentence written at minute 39 is unproofread by definition.

→ That sentence is the one that carries an error into a clean script.

The develop-don't-assert pattern

Every body paragraph, four moves:

Move	What it does
Claim	The idea, in one sentence.
Because	The mechanism — <i>why</i> it is true.
So what	The consequence — who gains, who loses, what follows.
Example	One concrete instance from your own knowledge. No invented statistics.

Before — asserted (band 6):

Remote work is convenient for employees. It saves time and money. Therefore many workers prefer it.

After — developed (band 7):

*Remote work removes the daily commute (**claim**), which for someone travelling into a capital from a satellite town can absorb two hours a day (**because**). Those hours are not merely saved; they are redirected into rest or into domestic work that would otherwise be crowded into the evening (**so what**). A parent commuting from [a satellite town] therefore recovers close to a working day every week (**example**).*

Same idea. Three times the marks.

Sentence starters that always work

Stating a position

In my view, [restrictions] are justified, but only where [the public alternative already exists].

Stating a partial position (for "to what extent")

This holds for [vocational subjects], but not for [the humanities].

Answering two questions in one line

The shift is driven mainly by [what has become easy], and on balance it is a [negative] development.

Topic sentence that carries the stance

The stronger reason for rejecting this claim is that [X].

Giving a reason

This matters because [mechanism], which means that [consequence].

Conceding

While [X] is undeniably true, it is an argument about [timing] rather than about [Y].

Conceding, short

There is real force in this objection, yet [counter].

Introducing an example

A [student] who [situation], for example, will [outcome].

Hedging

[Graduates] tend to [X], and in most cases [Y] is likely to follow.

Weighing one side against the other

The first cost is temporary and local; the second is permanent and shared.

Back-referencing a cause when you propose a remedy

The first of these causes is the easier to attack, because [reason].

Concluding with a reason

In conclusion, [verdict], because [the criterion the verdict rests on].

SPEAKING — the moves

The shape: Part 1 (4–5 min, 2–3 sentences per answer) · Part 2 (1 min prep, speak 2 min) · Part 3 (4–5 min, opinions and pushback).

1 Talk in Part 2 until the examiner stops you.

Aim past two minutes. Being cut off is a receipt, not a rebuke.

→ Stopping at 50 seconds forfeits the evidence band 7 needs.

2 Answer, reason, example — every Part 1 question.

Two to three sentences. Never a bare yes or no. Extend before you are asked why.

→ Flat two-clause answers are the band-6 signature.

3 Concede, then counter, whenever Part 3 pushes back.

"Granted, X — even so, Y." Pushback is designed in. Disagreeing costs you nothing.

→ Buys a concession clause and real depth in one breath.

4 Route round a missing word; never go silent.

Define it, give its function, or give an example. Then keep moving.

→ Paraphrase is scored. Not knowing the word is not.

5 Slow down. Speak measured, breathe between sentences.

Fast wrecks your rhythm. Very slow wrecks fluency. Sit between them.

→ Speed buys nothing and caps your pronunciation band.

6 Finish the sentence you started, even after a stall.

Pause, breathe, complete the structure. Restart only if the idea is genuinely gone.

→ Hesitation is allowed at band 7. Broken threads are not.

7 In the one minute, plan the tense and a spare.

Keywords only, two or three per bullet, plus the tense and one backup idea.

→ The spare line prevents the 50-second collapse.

8 Build every Part 3 answer in four steps.

Answer → because → for instance → although / which means. The fourth step separates bands.

→ Opinion, one reason, then stall — that is band 6.

9 Keep Part 3 general; use yourself only as an example.

Talk about people, not your family. The examiner will steer you off personal ground.

→ Personal answers in Part 3 cost you coherence marks.

10 Answer the rounding-off question in one sentence.

Straight after Part 2, short is correct: answer plus one clause, then stop.

→ A bare "yes" undoes two minutes of good English.

11 Ask for a repeat when you don't understand.

Allowed in Parts 1 and 3. Ask twice at most, then answer anyway.

→ Listening is not scored. Answering the wrong question is.

12 Mark your attitude in every Part 3 answer.

"Worryingly", "to be fair", "it's encouraging that", "I'm not entirely convinced".

→ Cheaper than rare vocabulary and worth more.

13 Use spoken links, never written ones.

"The thing is", "mind you", "which is why", "that said". Drop "moreover" and "furthermore".

→ Written connectives sound memorised the moment you say them.

14 Record every Part 2 and check three things.

Speech rate, even beats, where your pauses land. Nothing else. Five minutes.

→ The only feedback a book cannot give you.

Phrases to have ready

Buying time - "Let me see..." - "That's not something I've thought about much, actually." - "Well, it depends, really." - "How can I put this..."

Giving an opinion - "I'd say..." - "To be honest, I think..." - "If you ask me..." - "I'm not entirely convinced that..."

Conceding then countering - "Granted, ... even so, ..." - "True up to a point, though ..." - "I can see why people say that, although ..." - "There's something in that, but ..."

Comparing - "It's far more common than it was." - "Compared with, say, ten years ago..." - "Nothing like it used to be." - "It's less about X than about Y."

Speculating - "I'd imagine..." - "That could well lead to..." - "Chances are..." - "Presumably..."

Not knowing a word - "I don't know the technical term, but it's the thing you use to..." - "It's a sort of..." - "What's the word — something like..." - "You know, the kind of..."

Pronunciation — the only 3 things that matter for you

Slow down. Speak at the pace you'd use explaining something to a friend, and breathe at the end of every sentence. Rushing is what flattens your rhythm.

Stress-timing. English lands its beats evenly and crushes everything between them. Tap three beats on the table and force the words to fit: *CATS · EAT · FISH*

→ The CATS will EAT the FISH

→ The CATS would have EATen the FISH

— same time, every line. "Would have" becomes "wud-uv"; "the" becomes "thuh".

Chunking. Pause only at the joins between meaning units, never inside one. Read aloud stopping only at the slashes: *To be honest, / the thing I value most / is an old watch / my grandfather gave me / when I turned eighteen.*

The paper-strip drill for /p/. Hold a thin strip of paper near your lips. Say **pin – bin · pack – back · pear – bear · port – bought**. The paper must jump on every *p* and stay still on every *b*. Two minutes a day. Your /p/ isn't missing — it's missing air.

LANGUAGE — the moves

1 Remove errors before you add words.

Cutting ten mistakes moves your band. Adding ten new words does not.

→ You are marked on error density, not vocabulary size.

2 Hedge every sweeping claim.

"Tend to", "appears to", "in most cases", "may well". Delete every *all / always / never*.

→ The cheapest band-7 feature. Uses words you already own.

3 Learn phrases, never single words.

"Place a strain on", "pose a threat to", "address a problem". Card front = phrase with a gap.

→ Word partnerships are the assessed unit, not headwords.

4 Use compound nouns instead of adjectives you half-know.

Traffic congestion · income inequality · screen time · public transport · life expectancy.

→ Reads as topic command, near-zero error risk.

5 Choose the exact word, not the impressive one.

"Use" beats "utilise". Number = countable, amount = uncountable, rate = per something.

→ Reaching for a big word is the band-6 profile.

6 Never paraphrase a word that has no synonym.

"People", "in conclusion", "carbon dioxide". Repeat them without guilt.

→ A wrong substitution costs more than a repetition.

7 Learn your thirty spellings by rote.

Government · development · environment · maintenance · separate · definitely · necessary · successful.

→ Spelling is scored, and there is no spellchecker.

8 Repair every comma splice with a subordinator.

Swap the comma for *because, although, while, since*.

→ Turns a punctuation error into a complex structure.

9 Treat "however" as an adverb, not a joiner.

Full stop before it, comma after. Same for *therefore, moreover, nevertheless*.

→ Each one sitting in a splice kills two clauses.

10 Own the second conditional. Skip the third.

If governments taxed sugar, consumption would fall. No *would* inside the if-clause.

→ One pattern, drilled cold, beats three half-known ones.

11 Load your noun phrases before you add clauses.

One modifier in front, one behind: *enrolment*

→ the sharp fall in rural enrolment after 2015

.

→ Free grammatical range with almost no failure mode.

12 Stop writing three minutes early and only subtract.

Delete and repair. Never add a new sentence at the end.

→ The clever last sentence is where band 7 dies.

YOUR ERRORS — Arabic and French

Group	✗ Wrong	✓ Right
<i>Verb agreement</i>	Technology play an important role	Technology plays an important role
	A child who spend three hours online read less	A child who spends three hours online reads less
	Peoples are depend on transport	People depend on transport
	He do not agree	He does not agree
	Each of the regions have its own budget	Each of the regions has its own budget
<i>Run-ons</i>	Fees have doubled, however applications rise	Fees have doubled. However, applications rise
	It is cheap and it is used by many and it cuts traffic and ...	It is cheap and heavily used. Because it takes cars off the road, it cuts traffic
<i>Contrast</i>	Although the tax is unpopular, but it works	Although the tax is unpopular, it works
	Despite the tax is unpopular	Despite its unpopularity / Despite the fact that the tax is unpopular
<i>Relative clauses</i>	The reform which the ministry announced it	The reform which the ministry announced
	The district where they built the tramline in it	The district where they built the tramline
	Many households live below the line	Many households that live / living below the line
<i>Missing verb</i>	The main obstacle Ø the cost of transport	The main obstacle is the cost of transport
<i>Word order</i>	I eat never at the canteen	I never eat at the canteen
	my friends old from school	my old friends from school
	I have too much eaten	I have eaten too much
<i>Time</i>	running since ten years	running for ten years
	risen for 2015	risen since 2015
<i>Verb + object</i>	Online courses permit to study anytime	Online courses allow students to study anytime
<i>Passive</i>	An accident was happened	An accident happened

Group	✗ Wrong	✓ Right
	The number was risen sharply	The number rose sharply
<i>Spelling</i>	goverment · developement · enviroment · maintainance	government · development · environment · maintenance
	seperate · definately · succesful · broblem	separate · definitely · successful · problem
<i>Word form</i>	economical growth · significant rise	economic growth · significant rise

Articles — the one that decides band 6 vs 7

DROP "the" (talking in general): society · nature · technology · education · health · poverty · crime · unemployment · inflation · pollution · globalisation · tourism · agriculture · industry · science · history · art · music · life · knowledge · research · transport

KEEP "the" (even in general): the government · the environment · the media · the economy · the internet · the public · the police · the countryside · the weather · the climate · the state · the authorities · the past · the future

The check: if you can add "in general" after the noun, delete the *the* — unless it is on the KEEP list. The *the* comes straight back the moment an *of*-phrase, a relative clause, a superlative or a second mention arrives: *the impact of technology, the society we live in, the highest figure.*

The nine uncountables

information · advice · research · equipment · feedback · knowledge · software · furniture · evidence

Never plural. Never *a*. Never *many* or *fewer* — use *much, less, a great deal of, a piece of*. The verb behind them is singular: *Recent research shows, not researches show*. Add *people* to the scan: never *peoples*.

Prepositions that trip you

x	✓
<i>depend of</i>	depend on
<i>participate to</i>	participate in
<i>discuss about</i>	discuss Ø
<i>responsible of</i>	responsible for
<i>interested by</i>	interested in
<i>consist in</i>	consist of
<i>suffer of</i>	suffer from
<i>married with</i>	married to
<i>arrive to the city</i>	arrive in the city (at a building)
<i>in the other hand</i>	on the other hand
<i>focuses in</i>	focuses on
<i>contributed on</i>	contributed to

False friends that change your meaning

You write	You meant	Use
actually	currently	at present , these days
actual	current	current , present
eventually	possibly	possibly , potentially
assist (to) a lecture	attend	attend
formation	training	training , education
sensible	sensitive	sensitive
deception	disappointment	disappointment
support the noise	tolerate	tolerate , put up with
achieve a dissertation	finish	complete , finish
control the quality	check	check , inspect
demand someone to do	ask	ask someone to
significative	significant	significant
inconvenient (noun)	drawback	drawback , disadvantage
an important amount	a large amount	a large amount

Your 60-second proofread

Run this in the last three minutes. Do not read for meaning – you will read what you meant, not what you wrote.

1. **Commas.** Two complete sentences joined by a comma? Replace with *because* / *although* / *while*, or a full stop. Every *however* / *therefore* / *moreover* needs a full stop before it.
2. **Every "the".** Abstract noun, talked about in general, nothing attached after it? Delete – unless it is on the KEEP list.
3. **Every bare singular noun.** No article, no possessive, no quantifier? It needs *a/an* or *the*. And anything in the frame **___ of ___** almost always takes *the*.
4. **The nine uncountables.** Any of them carrying an -s? Delete it, then fix the verb behind it. Check *peoples* too.
5. **Verbs.** Singular subject in present simple – is the -s there, including inside relative clauses? Any two bare verbs stacked (*are depend*, *do not works*)?

6. **Your two longest sentences only.** *Although...but?* Delete the *but*. *Despite* + clause?

Rewrite. *which...it* / *who...them*? Delete the pronoun. *Would* in an if-clause? Change to past simple.

The rule that makes it work: in these three minutes you may delete and repair. You may not add.

TEST DAY — the running order

LISTENING · ~30 min

Before each part: read the questions. For every gap decide — number? name? plural? Write nothing yet.

While it plays: type as you hear. Never wait.

The three rules: - One answer per box. Two scores zero. - Never a blank. Guess something of the right type. - Answers come in order. Missed one? Go forward. Never hunt backwards.

At the end: 2 minutes. Check spelling and plurals only. Do not change answers.

READING · 60 min

Stop at 20 minutes per passage. Even mid-question. Even if it's nearly solved.

Order: Matching Headings early. Matching Information last.

Copy-paste from the passage for every completion answer. Ctrl+F does not work.

True / False / Not Given — one question:

Can I point at the sentence that contradicts this? **Yes → FALSE. No → NOT GIVEN.**

Never a blank.

WRITING · 60 min

If you run out of time on tests, do Task 2 first. It is worth double.

Task 1 — 20 min

0-5	Read. Spot the biggest pattern. Decide your two groups.
5-17	Intro (1 sentence) → Overview (2) → Body 1 → Body 2
17	STOP WRITING
17-20	Check

No conclusion. No opinions. No causes.

Task 2 — 40 min

0-5 Underline EVERY part of the question. Plan 2 ideas.
5-37 Intro → Body 1 → Body 2 → Conclusion
37 STOP WRITING
37-40 The 60-second proofread

260–290 words. Longer is fine if it's accurate.

SPEAKING · 11–14 min

Part 1 — Answer + reason + example. Two or three sentences. Never one word.

Part 2 — The prep minute is for **keywords, not sentences**. Speak the full two minutes. **Being stopped means you spoke long enough.**

Part 3 — Expect pushback. It is not hostility, it is the test. **Concede, then hold your ground with a reason.**

Don't know a word? Paraphrase it. That scores band 7, not zero.

When you get stuck

Paper	Do this
Listening	Guess. Move forward. Never chase backwards.
Reading	Hard stop. Next passage.
Task 1	Write the overview, then two body paragraphs.
Task 2	Answer the question that was actually asked.
Speaking	Answer, reason, example. Then stop talking.

The night before

Read this page and your error card. Nothing else. Bag: ID (**the same document you booked with**), booking confirmation, water.

Sleep. Tiredness destroys accuracy first, and accuracy is where band 7 lives.

One bad section does not decide your band

The average of four does. A 5.5 in one paper survives if the other three hold. Finish every paper. Never leave a box empty.